The Guardian

one stop english

Japan PM's solution to dire birth rate has already been rejected by young

Level 2: Intermediate

1 Warmer

a. Discuss these questions.

> **dire:** very bad
> **birth rate:** the officially recorded number of births in a particular year or place

1. Do you know countries in which the population is increasing? How about countries where it is decreasing?
2. Why do you think fewer people are choosing to have children in certain societies?
3. Why is a lower birth rate making governments worried?
4. Do you think it is possible to convince younger generations to have children when they don't want to? If so, how?

2 Key words

a. Find the following words in the text. The paragraph numbers are given to help you. Complete the sentences to use the word in context.

1. a noun meaning *someone who thinks that the worst thing will happen in every situation* _____ (paragraph 2)
   I take after my grandmother who is a total _____ *– she always expects the worst.*
2. an adjective meaning *relating to populations* _____ (paragraph 2)
   The magazine article is about population changes and global _____ *trends.*
3. an adverb meaning *in a way that is very difficult to change or to defeat* _____ (paragraph 2)
   Despite their efforts, sales remained _____ *low.*
4. a noun meaning *something that makes you want to do something or to work harder because you know that you will benefit by doing this* _____ (paragraph 5)
   The government is providing tax _____ *for people to get married.*
5. a noun meaning *a difficulty or problem that prevents you from achieving something* _____ (paragraph 5)
   She had to overcome many _____ *before becoming a professional musician.*

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6. a noun meaning *the job of looking after children, especially while their parents are working* _____ (paragraph 6)
   Parents are relieved about three more _____ *spaces opening in the community.*

7. a noun meaning *amounts of money that the government or another organization pays to help to reduce the cost of a product or service* _____ (paragraph 7)
   Farmers receive _____ *to grow corn, soy, and wheat.*

8. an adjective meaning *not willing to do something* _____ (paragraph 7)
   I was _____ *to leave before they announced the winners.*

9. a noun meaning *something that you very much want to do, usually something that is difficult to achieve* _____ (paragraph 9)
   I had no idea that his _____ *was to work in law.*

10. a noun meaning *a worried feeling you have caused by a problem or situation* _____ (paragraph 10)
    Most adults feel stressed out by the _____ *of modern life.*

11. a verb meaning *pause before doing something, or do something very slowly, usually because you are nervous, embarrassed or worried* _____ (paragraph 10)
    Please do not _____ *to contact us if you have any questions.*

12. a noun meaning *a lack of something that you need or want* _____ (paragraph 12)
    There has been a _____ *of eggs after an outbreak of bird flu.*

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Justin McCurry

24 January 2023

1 Fumio Kishida gave a warning to the Japanese people: have more children or risk dragging their country into dysfunction.

2 His transformation from pleasant career politician to pessimist is a reflection of the demographic crisis facing Japan, one of the fastest-ageing countries on earth. As he said in a speech to parliament, the number of births in Japan is estimated to have sunk below 800,000 in 2022. He said the stubbornly low birth rate "cannot wait and cannot be postponed."

3 Solving Japan's demographic crisis has been impossible for occupants of the Kantei – the prime minister's office – long before Kishida moved in. The population of the world's third-biggest economy has been in decline for several years, and suffered a record fall of 644,000 in 2020–21, according to government data. It is expected to decline from its current 125 million to an estimated 88 million in 2065 – a 30 per cent decrease in 45 years.

4 The birth rate remains at 1.3 – the average number of children a woman will have in her lifetime – way below the 2.1 needed to keep the population stable. And the number of over-65s continues to grow – it is now more than 28 per cent of the population.

5 The government has combined silly requests to "go home and multiply" with financial incentives for couples who do. There were no policies that address structural obstacles to raising the birth rate in Kishida's speech. Instead, he spoke about a "child-first social economy", led by a new children and families agency.

6 Under loose plans, families will receive bigger child allowances and working parents will have access to more after-school childcare. Reforms will make it easier for parents to take leave to raise families – all funded by a doubling in spending on children that will be finalized in June.

7 But Japan's previous efforts have had limited impact. Subsidies for pregnancy, childbirth and childcare have failed, while some experts complain that politicians target parents who already have children while failing to ask themselves why young people are reluctant to start families.

8 They are talking about women like Nao Imai, a university student. "I used to think I would be married by 25 and a mother by 27," she said. "But when I look at my eldest sister, who has a two-year-old girl, I'm afraid to have children. When you have a child in Japan, the husband keeps working but the mother is expected to quit her job and look after the children. I just feel that it's hard to raise children – financially, mentally and physically."

9 Imai is not alone. A survey by the Nippon Foundation found that only 16.5 per cent of people aged 17 to 19 believed they would get married, even though a much larger number wanted to do so. The problems appear when ambitions meet economic reality.

10 Kishida's speech did not contain specifics about the pressures couples say are making them hesitate before having children: the expense of compulsory and higher education, the cost of living, badly paid and unstable jobs for non-regular workers, and long working hours that make a healthy family life impossible.

11 While Japan waits for more details, the Liberal Democratic party sends out a very different message. Taro Aso, a former prime minister with a history of embarrassing public mistakes, blamed the low birth rate on women who marry too late to make larger families a realistic option.

12 Kishida warned that Japan had reached a "now or never moment" to solve its problem of a shortage of children. If experience tells us anything, "never" is more likely.

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3 Comprehension check

a. Are these statements *true* or *false* according to the article? Correct any that are false.

1. There were fewer than 800,000 births in Japan in 2022. _____
2. There will be almost 40 million more people in Japan in 45 years. _____
3. The number of people older than 65 keeps on decreasing. _____
4. The government is telling people to go home and have more children. _____
5. Providing money for pregnancy and childcare has been a successful government strategy so far. _____
6. Many women decide not to have children because of the economic and emotional difficulties involved. _____
7. The cost of education and bad work–life balance are two of the reasons given for not having children. _____
8. Kishida blamed the demographic crisis on women who marry too late. _____
9. The writer thinks it might already be too late for Japan to fix its demographic issue. _____

4 Key language

a. Complete the table with the words and phrases from the article.

be in decline / decline | continue to grow | decrease | remain at | sink | suffer a fall

Upward movement	Downward movement	No movement

b. Choose three words from part A and write a sentence with each.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

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5 Discussion

a. Discuss these statements.

- "Having children is a personal choice. Governments should not try to influence people."
- "It is everyone's right to have children, so governments have to support those who do."
- "There is enough pressure on the environment with the current global population, so governments shouldn't encourage more people to start families."

6 In your own words

a. Look online for information about the countries with the highest and lowest birth rates. Find out how the governments are dealing with this.

b. Report your findings to the class.

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